

Note that in the shell environment, the string index will start with 0, so if you mention 3 as the position, then it will print from the 4th character.

Alternatively, we can also use *expr* to do the same operation:

```
expr substr "$String" $position $length
```

For example:

```
expr substr "$String" 4 5
```

Note that if you are using *expr*, the string index will start with 1. So you have to mention the exact position of the character.

—R.Satheesh Kumar, sathees.r@hcl.in

Change the case of files at one go

Sometimes, when we are copying files from a CD (which contains files written from MS-Windows) to a Linux system, all the file names appear in capital letters. Since in Linux, file names are generally in lower case, we would naturally want to rename all file names to lower case letters at one go. In this case, instead of renaming all files one by one using the *mv* command, we can execute the following command to change file names to lower case:

```
convmv -lower --notest *
```

This will change all file names in the current directory to lower case.

—Pankaj Kumar, pankaj@glug4muz.org

Execute a command at a specific time

The *at* command is used to run a command at a specific time or date. For example, in order to remove a directory after one minute, issue the following commands:

```
# at now +1 min
at> rmdir lfy
at> updatedb
at> <CTRL-D>
```

To remove a directory on a particular day, say on MM/DD/YYYY, use the code below:

```
# at MM/DD/YYYY
at> rmdir lfy
at> updatedb
at> <CTRL-D>
```

—M Sambenny, msambenny@gmail.com



Play music in VLC without a GUI

In your terminal prompt, type the following:

```
vlc -I ncurses /home/dan/filename.mp3
```

Where the *-I* option is, specify the interface—in our case, it's *ncurses*. It will open an *ncurses* interface in the terminal, where you can increase or decrease the volume by using *A* or *Z* keys and press *H* for further options.

Also note that */home/dan/filename.mp3* is an example of a music file. You can open any number of files by using a wildcard such as ***. For example, */home/dan/*.mp3*

—Bhuvanesh Kumar, bhuvibhuvanesh@gmail.com



Carrots are good for you!

Most often, when we try to execute a command at the shell, we make mistakes like missing out a char or misspelling it. Here is an easy way of correcting the mistakes without having to type the entire command again!

In the following command, 'naem' has been misspelled as 'naem'.

```
$ find -naem "*.txt" -print
find: invalid predicate '-naem'
```

The above command would be valid if we replace "em" (in naem) to "me". Use carrots to make this change:

```
$ ^em^me^
find -name "*.txt" -print
```

This technique works well with Bash and csh shells.

—Sunil Krishnan K, sunilkrishnank@gmail.com



Get server e-mail alerts on the root login

Append the following line at the end of your *~/.bashrc* file.

```
echo 'ALERT - Root Shell Access on:' `date` `who` | mail -s 'Alert: Root Access from `who`' `awk '{print $6}'` your_mail_address
```

—Mallikarjun, mallik.v.arjun@gmail.com

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